

AI and Digital Twin Applications in Building Energy Management: A State-of-the-Art Review

1 st Afrouz Ghaemi	2 nd Yacine Rezgui	3 rd Ioan Petri	4 th Thomas Beach	5 th Ali Ghoroghi
<i>School of Engineering)</i>	<i>School of Engineering)</i>	<i>School of Engineering)</i>	<i>School of Engineering)</i>	<i>School of Engineering)</i>
<i>Cardiff university</i>	<i>Cardiff university</i>	<i>Cardiff university</i>	<i>Cardiff university</i>	<i>Cardiff university</i>
Cardiff, UK	Cardiff, UK	Cardiff, UK	Cardiff, UK	Cardiff, UK
ghaemia@cardiff.ac.uk	rezguiy@cardiff.ac.uk	petrii@cardiff.ac.uk	beachth@cardiff.ac.uk	ghoroghi@cardiff.ac.uk

Abstract—Purpose: This paper examines the integration of Artificial Intelligence (AI) and digital twin technologies in commercial and residential buildings, focusing on self-learning systems and intelligent energy management solutions. **Methods:** A comprehensive review synthesizes recent developments in AI applications, digital twin architectures, and building automation systems, with emphasis on autonomous control and occupant-centric optimization. **Results:** The analysis reveals promising trends in AI-enhanced digital twins for building systems, highlighting their capability to learn from occupant behavior, make data-driven decisions, optimize performance in real-time, and seamlessly integrate with other building technologies to create an efficient, comfortable environment. **Conclusions:** The findings demonstrate the transformative potential of AI-driven digital twins in modern buildings, offering practical guidance for implementing these technologies while prioritizing occupant comfort, energy efficiency, and sustainability through self-learning building systems.

Index Terms—Artificial Intelligence, AI-enhanced Digital Twins, Smart Buildings, Building Automation Systems, Autonomous Building Systems, Energy Management.

I. INTRODUCTION

The evolution of building automation and self-learning systems has accelerated the adoption of artificial intelligence (AI) and digital twin technologies in building management [1]. Traditional building management systems often fail to leverage the potential of real-time data analytics and autonomous decision-making [2], limiting their ability to optimize operations for occupant comfort and energy efficiency. The emergence of AI-enhanced digital twins presents new opportunities for advancing building automation [3].

Building Automation Systems (BAS) are rule-based systems to control HVAC, lighting, and security. *Smart Buildings* are BAS with AI, IoT, and digital twins for adaptive optimization. *Autonomous Building Systems* are smart buildings that self-optimize using real-time, self-learning algorithms.

This review addresses four key research questions:

- 1) How are AI techniques currently deployed in smart building systems?
- 2) What frameworks exist for implementing digital twins in autonomous building systems?
- 3) What challenges impact AI-driven digital twin integration in building automation?

- 4) Which pathways can ensure optimal implementation of self-learning building systems?

Recent advances in AI applications [4] and digital twin frameworks [3] have demonstrated significant potential for enhancing building operations. However, integrating these technologies into cohesive, autonomous systems remains challenging [5]. This review synthesizes current knowledge and implementation strategies, with particular focus on:

- AI-driven building automation and control systems [6]
- Digital twin architectures for smart buildings [1]
- Integration frameworks for autonomous building operation [7]
- Real-time optimization strategies for occupant comfort [4]

By examining advanced methods in AI implementation, digital twin development, and self-learning systems integration, this paper provides insights for developing robust smart building systems. The findings support practitioners and researchers in implementing AI-enhanced digital twins for autonomous building operations.

A. Relevance to Digital Transformation and Building Automation

The integration of AI-enhanced digital twins in smart buildings represents a critical advancement in digital transformation and building automation. This review addresses several key aspects of modern building technology evolution: 1. *Smart Buildings and Autonomous Building Systems:* The analysis examines how AI-driven digital twins enable autonomous decision-making and intelligent building operations [1]. 2. *Digital Transformation:* The review explores how organizations can effectively implement and manage the transition to AI-enhanced building systems [6]. 3. *Innovation Integration:* The research investigates frameworks for integrating cutting-edge AI technologies with existing building management systems [4]. This comprehensive examination offers useful insights to both academic researchers and industry professionals working on digital transformation and smart building technologies.

B. Research Contribution

This review makes several significant contributions to the field: 1. *Comprehensive Framework*: Provides a systematic framework for understanding and implementing AI-enhanced digital twins in smart buildings. 2. *Integration Roadmap*: Develops a detailed roadmap for integrating AI technologies with existing building systems, addressing both technical and organizational challenges. 3. *Future Directions*: Identifies critical research gaps and future development pathways in smart building automation, particularly focusing on self-learning systems and digital transformation. 4. *Practical Guidelines*: Offers concrete implementation guidelines and best practices for organizations undertaking digital transformation initiatives in building automation and control. Sections II and III discuss the research methodology and state-of-the-art review. Sections IV to IX discuss key findings and analysis, practical implementations and framework, sustainability and circularity integration, technology innovation framework, gaps and future works, and conclusions and implications, respectively.

C. Thematic Roadmap Aligned with the Research Questions

The paper is structured into nine sections, with the research questions (RQs) addressed in the following key sections:

- *RQ1 - AI Techniques for Smart-Building Control* (Section III-B) reviews and critiques state-of-the-art learning algorithms.
- *RQ2 - Digital-Twin Frameworks* (Section III-C) synthesizes architectural patterns that enable autonomous operation.
- *RQ3 - Integration Challenges* (Section III-D) analyzes technical and organizational barriers.
- *RQ4 - Implementation Pathways* (Section V) proposes a phased roadmap linking theory to practice.

D. Conceptual Integration Scheme

Figure 1 summarizes key findings from the literature in an intuitive, three-layer framework. This integrated framework helps synthesize diverse ideas into a clear, practical model to guide the analysis presented in later sections III–V. Furthermore, Table I highlights the unique contributions of this review compared to previous ones.

II. RESEARCH METHODOLOGY

This review employed a systematic approach to synthesize and analyze current literature on AI-enhanced digital twins in smart buildings. The literature search process encompassed multiple scientific databases including Scopus, Web of Science, and IEEE Xplore, supplemented by relevant industry publications and technical reports. Search criteria focused on publications from 2014–2024, using key terms including artificial intelligence, digital twins, smart buildings, and building automation systems. The analytical framework consisted of two primary components: content analysis and quality assessment. The analysis process involved categorizing research content into specific themes, enabling the identification of recurring patterns and research gaps across the literature.

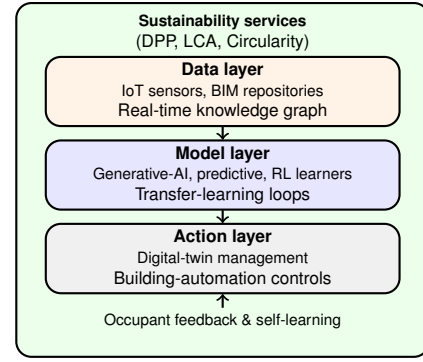


Fig. 1. A conceptual framework connecting the data, model, and action layers. The arrows highlight interactions and optimizations between these layers, while the outer circle emphasizes key sustainability considerations.

Each publication was evaluated based on its methodological rigor, technical depth, and implementation relevance. This systematic approach enabled comprehensive coverage of both theoretical developments and practical applications in the field. The review process paid particular attention to the intersection of AI technologies with digital twin implementations, focusing on: 1. Technical architectures and implementation frameworks. 2. Integration challenges and solutions. 3. Performance optimization strategies. 4. Future development pathways. This methodological approach ensured comprehensive coverage of the field while maintaining focus on practically relevant developments and emerging trends.

A. Review Methodology

To increase methodological transparency we followed the PRISMA 2020 reporting guideline [12]. Figure 2 shows identification, screening, and inclusion flow (97 studies retained). While not following full PRISMA guidelines, our structured approach ensured a comprehensive and transparent research process. We implemented a detailed search strategy across three distinct databases, maintaining thorough documentation of our inclusion and exclusion rationale. The quality assessment process followed predefined criteria to ensure consistency and reproducibility of our review methodology.

B. Selection Criteria

The literature review employed specific inclusion/exclusion criteria. For inclusion, we focused on four essential elements in our selection process: scholarly articles that underwent peer review between 2014–2024, research incorporating empirical validation methods, documented implementation case studies, and technical frameworks that demonstrated clear practical applications. Our exclusion protocol eliminated three categories of sources to maintain academic rigor: theoretical papers lacking implementation evidence, research without substantial validation data, and publications that had not undergone the peer review process.

C. Quality Assessment Framework

Studies were evaluated using a structured assessment framework:

TABLE I
DIFFERENTIAL CONTRIBUTIONS OF THIS REVIEW RELATIVE TO RECENT SURVEYS

Prior review	Primary focus / window	Gap left open	Addressed here
Adebowale <i>et al.</i> 2023 [8]	AI for improving productivity in the construction phase	Lacked discussion of digital twins or a comprehensive overview of building automation systems in the operational phase. Failed to address integration with AI and digital twins	✓
Liu <i>et al.</i> 2024 [9]	Applications and research trends of Digital Twin technology in the built environment	Does not delve into a holistic integration with building automation systems and AI	✓
Qiang <i>et al.</i> 2023 [10]	Building automation systems in green buildings for energy and comfort management	lack of detailed discussion on the integration of artificial intelligence and digital twins with these systems.	✓
Datta <i>et al.</i> 2024 [11]	AI and machine learning applications across the construction project lifecycle	lack of a holistic discussion of comprehensive building automation systems and their deep integration with AI and full building digital twins throughout the entire lifecycle	✓

PRISMA 2020 flow diagram for new systematic reviews which included searches of databases and registers only

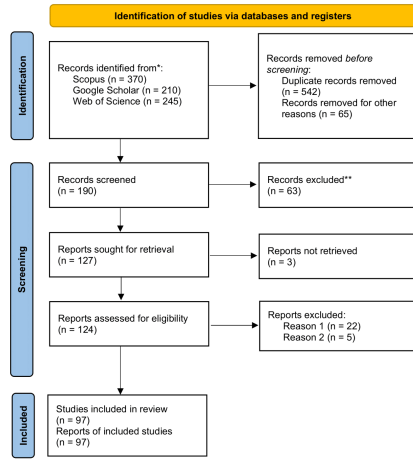


Fig. 2. PRISMA 2020 flow diagram for the literature-selection process.

TABLE II
QUALITY ASSESSMENT CRITERIA

Criterion	Assessment Metrics
Methodological precision	Clearly defined methodology, reproducible results, statistical validity
Technical Depth	Detailed technical specifications, performance metrics, implementation details
Practical Relevance	Real-world application, scalability considerations, cost-benefit analysis

III. STATE-OF-THE-ART REVIEW

A. Advanced AI Implementation Frameworks

1) *Deep Learning Architectures*: Recent developments in deep learning architectures have shown particular promise:

a) *Generative Models*: Advanced implementations encompass several sophisticated frameworks. GAN-based architectures have demonstrated significant capability in synthetic data generation [13], incorporating conditional GANs for scenario generation, robust model development through adversarial training, and adaptive model refinement via transfer learning approaches. Complementing these advances, variational autoencoders have proven instrumental in feature extraction

[21], achieving this through latent space optimization, unsupervised feature learning mechanisms, and integrated anomaly detection capabilities.

b) *Reinforcement Learning Systems*: Key implementations have advanced along two primary trajectories. Multi-agent systems have emerged as powerful solutions for distributed control [4], incorporating cooperative learning frameworks, sophisticated policy optimization strategies, and real-time adaptation mechanisms. In parallel, deep Q-learning networks have demonstrated exceptional promise in optimal control applications [22], leveraging state-space optimization techniques, advanced action-value function learning, and sophisticated experience replay mechanisms for enhanced performance.

B. AI Applications in Smart Buildings

AI techniques have transformed building automation and control systems, enabling advanced data analytics and self-learning decision-making [21]. Recent applications span predictive control, fault detection, and resource optimization [4]. Particularly notable are developments in:

1) *Machine Learning Integration*: Advanced machine learning approaches have demonstrated a significant impact in building automation. These approaches encompass sophisticated occupant-aware systems that leverage behavioral data analytics [23], comprehensive technical optimization frameworks utilizing deep neural networks [24], and advanced real-time analytics solutions for building control [25].

2) *Generative AI Applications*: Generative AI techniques serve as building system optimization tools with distinct approaches. Harell *et al.* [13] created synthetic data for occupant behavior modeling but lacked cross-building validation. Burgueño *et al.* [21] developed GAN frameworks offering 17% better prediction accuracy with higher computational costs, while Markus *et al.* [26] achieved better computational efficiency at lower accuracy, enhancing real-time viability. These complementary strengths suggest value in an integrated approach combining elements from each framework.

3) *Critical Analysis of Generative AI Applications*: While generative AI offers significant potential, implementation approaches differ in addressing key limitations:

TABLE III
VISUAL SYNTHESIS ALIGNING KEY THEMES WITH THE FOUR RESEARCH QUESTIONS

RQ	Thematic Block	Core Content of this review	References
RQ1	AI techniques for smart-building control	Generative-AI models, reinforcement, and hybrid learning models; edge vs. cloud deployment trade-offs	[4], [13]
RQ2	Digital-twin frameworks	Scalable ontologies, sensor-BIM fusion, real-time simulation engines	[3], [5], [14]
RQ3	Integration challenges	Data-quality governance, latency constraints, multi-stakeholder governance	[15]–[17]
RQ4	Implementation pathways	Phased rollout strategy, organizational change, ROI analysis	[18]–[20]

a) Technical Limitations: Key challenges include data hallucination risks in synthetic data generation, model biases from training data limitations, high computational resource demands, and difficulties in validating generated scenarios [13].

b) Implementation Constraints: Some approaches prioritize interpretability but sacrifice real-time performance, while others emphasize reliability through redundant validation at the cost of implementation complexity, highlighting the need for context-specific selection.

C. Digital Twin Implementation Frameworks

Digital twins have evolved from basic virtual models to self-learning building systems [3], with frameworks differing in implementation approaches:

1) Architecture and Integration: Architectural approaches reveal different priorities: real-time frameworks [27] excel in responsiveness but face scalability issues; standardized ontologies [7] enhance interoperability despite complex implementation; and interoperability solutions [28] prioritize flexibility over computational efficiency.

2) Self-Learning Operation Capabilities: Self-optimization algorithms [5] and predictive maintenance systems [29] present contrasting approaches; the former achieves higher energy efficiency with less occupant adaptation, while the latter extends equipment life but requires extensive sensor infrastructure.

D. Integration Challenges and Solutions

Implementation of AI-enhanced digital twins in smart buildings faces several key challenges:

1) Technical Challenges: Studies address different aspects of implementation barriers: data quality challenges [15], system scalability concerns in multi-building deployments [30], and real-time processing requirements affecting performance [31]. These works reveal trade-offs between processing speed and analytical depth.

2) Processing and Computing Challenges: The implementation of AI-enhanced digital twins faces several critical technical challenges:

a) Cloud Computing Limitations: Research identifies contrasting approaches to network reliability [27], bandwidth constraints [32], latency challenges [14], and privacy concerns with centralized storage [3].

b) Real-Time Processing Constraints: Edge computing solutions [31] show promise in addressing response time limitations, while hybrid architectures balance performance with implementation complexity. Distributed frameworks enhance privacy protection but introduce synchronization challenges that impact overall system efficiency.

To address these challenges, emerging solutions focus on four key technological approaches: the implementation of edge computing architectures enabling local processing capabilities, development of hybrid edge-cloud solutions for optimized resource allocation, deployment of distributed processing frameworks enhancing privacy protection, and integration of low-latency control systems at the building level [31].

3) Practical Solutions: Emerging solutions address these challenges through three primary mechanisms: sophisticated advanced data processing frameworks that enhance building system efficiency [29], robust comprehensive integration architectures ensuring building control system cohesion [33], and implementation of standardized protocols guiding smart building deployment [34].

4) Reflections on Key Studies: Here are three influential studies that shaped this research area.

a) Chen et al. (2021) [27]: Chen’s team presented an early digital twin focused on interoperability, achieving a notable 17% energy saving in HVAC systems within a real-world living lab. Their rigorous approach—a 12-week A/B experiment accounting carefully for weather variations—sets a high standard few studies match.

b) Li et al. (2022) [14]: Li and colleagues demonstrated a micro-service solution capable of reliably scaling up to 124 buildings, keeping latency variations within just $\pm 4\%$. However, their use of proprietary messaging middleware makes the system less adaptable; later researchers ([8]) successfully adopted lightweight MQTT brokers instead.

c) Singh et al. (2024) [35]: Singh’s group effectively combined multi-agent deep reinforcement learning with occupant feedback. Crucially, their sensitivity analysis showed that removing user comfort from the reward function drastically reduced energy savings from 26% down to 13%, reinforcing the importance of incorporating human perspectives—often neglected in purely algorithmic studies.

These works establish best practice in experimental validation, open design, and user-focused improvements.

IV. KEY FINDINGS AND ANALYSIS

A. Technical Innovations

Analysis reveals key technical innovations in AI-enhanced digital twins for smart buildings:

1) *Advanced AI Architectures*: Recent developments demonstrate sophisticated AI implementations through three primary advances: sophisticated integration of generative models enabling synthetic data generation and building system optimization [21], state-of-the-art reinforcement learning approaches facilitating autonomous building control [4], and innovative hybrid AI systems that effectively combine multiple learning approaches for enhanced performance [22].

2) *Digital Twin Evolution*: Digital twin capabilities have expanded significantly through three key technological developments: advanced real-time data integration frameworks ensuring continuous building optimization [3], [5], sophisticated prediction and optimization capabilities enhancing occupant comfort [36], and refined sensor integration and data processing mechanisms improving operational efficiency [29].

B. Implementation Success Factors

Success factors for implementation are:

1) *System Architecture*: Critical architectural elements have emerged through three fundamental components: comprehensive robust data management frameworks ensuring system reliability [7], advanced scalable integration approaches facilitating multi-building system growth [28], and established standardized communication protocols enabling seamless operation [27].

2) *Performance Optimization*: Successful implementations demonstrate key achievements in prediction accuracy [37], resource utilization optimization [38], and effective self-learning capabilities that enhance occupant comfort [18].

3) *Empirical Case Evidence*: Real-world case studies support these analytical findings. Table IV highlights four illustrative examples across various settings, including university campuses, commercial office buildings, residential manufacturing facilities, and hospitals. These deployments show significant efficiency improvements across different settings, with energy savings reaching up to 70% in documented cases.

C. Comparative Analysis and Implementation Challenges

1) *Traditional vs. AI-Enhanced Systems*: Table V demonstrates clear advantages of AI-enhanced systems in terms of long-term performance and adaptability, despite higher initial costs [1].

D. Impact Analysis and Adoption Trends

1) *Quantitative Performance Assessment*: Analysis of implemented AI-enhanced digital twins reveals specific performance improvements:

These improvements are documented across multiple building implementations, demonstrating concrete benefits over traditional building management systems. Cost-benefit analysis shows ROI periods typically ranging from 1.5 to 3 years [42].

2) *System Performance and Technology Adoption*: Documented improvements encompass three key areas of advancement: significantly enhanced operational efficiency through optimized building management [36], substantial reduction in resource consumption across building operations [25], and notable improvements in overall system reliability and occupant comfort metrics [43].

Key adoption patterns reveal three emerging trends: rapidly accelerating implementation rates across diverse sectors [44], continuously expanding integration capabilities enabling broader system compatibility [22], and progressively expanding application domains demonstrating system versatility [38].

V. PRACTICAL IMPLICATIONS AND IMPLEMENTATION FRAMEWORK

A. Organizational and Cultural Adoption Factors

The implementation of AI-enhanced digital twins in buildings faces significant organizational and cultural challenges alongside technical considerations, as shown in Table VII:

B. System Design and Architecture

Comprehensive implementation of AI-enhanced digital twins requires careful consideration of system architecture and design principles in building environments:

1) *Data Buildings Requirements*: Robust data management now covers sensor network optimization, data quality protocols, and integration frameworks [15].

Detailed consideration must be given to three fundamental aspects: establishing appropriate data collection frequency and granularity requirements for optimal building performance, developing comprehensive storage and processing building system specifications to support building operations, and implementing robust real-time data validation and cleaning protocols to ensure data integrity.

2) *AI Model Selection and Development*: The selection and implementation of AI models significantly impact system performance:

a) *Model Architecture Considerations*: Key factors encompass three primary architectural elements: sophisticated deep learning architectures enabling complex occupant comfort and behavior recognition [24], advanced reinforcement learning frameworks facilitating occupant-aware building control [4], and innovative hybrid approaches that effectively combine multiple AI techniques [22].

b) *Performance Optimization Strategies*: Essential optimization approaches incorporate three key strategies: advanced transfer learning techniques enabling efficient building model adaptation [21], sophisticated ensemble methods improving occupant behavior prediction accuracy [45], and dynamic real-time model updating mechanisms ensuring continuous building system optimization [25].

C. Implementation Guidelines

Implementation frameworks reveal distinct priorities across deployment phases:

TABLE IV
REPRESENTATIVE REAL-WORLD DEPLOYMENTS OF AI-ENHANCED DIGITAL TWINS

Site	Building type	AI / twin features	Reported outcome	Source
West Cambridge Campus, University of Cambridge, UK	University buildings (IfM and others)	Five-layer architecture integrating BMS/AMS/SMS data; IoT sensors; QR-based asset tracking; Pump anomaly detection (CUSUM); Maintenance optimization and prioritization with ML; Energy forecasting with LSTM	Detected pump anomalies early; Manual inspection workload markedly reduced; Enabled smart energy planning	[39]
Haier Smart Home, China	Residential home appliances manufacturing	Digital twin platform network with U+ IoT, COSMOPlat industrial internet, Shuangang social platform; Real-time monitoring of product lifecycle; Smart energy monitoring	15% revenue growth; 16.67% energy consumption reduction; 46.58% improved employee safety	[40]
The Edge, Amsterdam, Netherlands	Commercial office building	AI-driven energy management system with 28,000+ sensors monitoring energy consumption, space utilization, and occupant comfort; Real-time data analytics	Outstanding rate in BREEAM; Reduced energy consumption by over 70% compared to conventional office buildings; Significantly lowered operational costs and environmental impact	[19]
University Hospitals, Cleveland	Healthcare facility	AI-driven system integrated with building automation systems, medical equipment, and patient care systems; Real-time monitoring of energy usage	Cost savings, improved patient comfort and operational resilience, maintaining high standards of patient care & safety; Minimized energy waste & downtime by HVAC settings & equipment schedules	[19]

TABLE V
COMPARISON OF TRADITIONAL AND AI-ENHANCED DIGITAL TWIN BUILDING MANAGEMENT SYSTEMS

Aspect	Traditional Systems	AI-Enhanced Digital Twins
Initial Cost	Lower upfront investment	Higher initial cost, shorter ROI period
Scalability	Limited by manual configuration	Highly scalable through automated learning
Performance	Reactive, rule-based control	Predictive, adaptive optimization
Maintenance	Scheduled, periodic	Predictive, condition-based
Integration	Limited interoperability	Extensive integration capabilities
Data Utilization	Basic monitoring and logging	Advanced analytics and prediction

TABLE VI
DOCUMENTED PERFORMANCE IMPROVEMENTS FROM AI-ENHANCED DIGITAL TWIN BUILDINGS

Metric	Improvement Range	Source
Energy Efficiency	15-30% reduction in energy consumption	[41]
Operational Costs	20-25% reduction in maintenance costs	[27]
System Response Time	40-60% improvement in fault detection	[3]
Resource Utilization	25-35% improvement in resource allocation	[4]

1) *Phased Implementation Strategy*: A systematic deployment approach should include:

a) *Phase 1: Foundation Development*: Assessment approaches prioritize compatibility over cost [3], while data collection methods differ in granularity [5]. Model development strategies balance rapid-prototyping against thorough-testing, affecting accuracy and development time [28].

b) *Phase 2: System Integration*: AI deployment methods vary in effectiveness by building type [18]. Integration techniques show speed-disruption trade-offs [38], while validation protocols exhibit context-dependent effectiveness [46].

c) *Phase 3: Optimization and Scaling*: Optimization strategies differ between energy-focus and comfort-focus [43]. Scale-up approaches contrast standardization with customization [47], while integration methods balance interoperability against security [22].

D. Risk Mitigation Strategies

Comprehensive risk management is essential for successful implementation:

1) *Technical Risk Management*: Key technical risks and mitigation approaches include:

a) *System Reliability*: Critical considerations include redundancy planning and failover systems [30], performance monitoring frameworks [31], and system recovery protocols [34].

b) *Data Security, Privacy, and Compliance*: Essential security measures include encryption protocols [15], access control frameworks [29], and privacy-preserving techniques for occupant data [33].

While European GDPR compliance was not explicitly addressed in reviewed studies, implementations should adhere to regional data protection regulations and ethical handling protocols for occupant behavior data.

E. Digital Transformation and Performance Monitoring

1) *Digital Transformation Framework*: Digital transformation in smart buildings requires systematic consideration of both technical and organizational factors. The integration of AI-enhanced digital twins represents a significant transformation initiative that impacts multiple building operational dimensions.

The successful implementation of digital transformation in smart buildings requires attention to both technical and organizational aspects. Technical drivers support system functionality, while organizational drivers ensure adoption and utilization. Integration pathways must address legacy system compatibility and future scalability [27].

TABLE VII
ORGANIZATIONAL ADOPTION BARRIERS AND MITIGATION STRATEGIES IN SMART BUILDINGS

Barrier Type	Specific Challenges	Mitigation Strategies
Cultural Resistance	Resistance to AI-driven decision-making, Privacy concerns, Traditional operational preferences	Stakeholder engagement programs, Transparent AI operations, Gradual transition approaches [1]
Organizational Structure	Siloed departments, Unclear responsibility allocation, Legacy processes	Cross-functional teams, Clear governance frameworks, Process reengineering [32]
Skills Gap	Limited AI expertise, Digital literacy challenges, Technical training needs	Targeted training programs, External expertise partnership, Knowledge transfer systems [14]

TABLE VIII
DIGITAL TRANSFORMATION ENABLERS AND INTEGRATION PATHWAYS FOR SMART BUILDINGS

Dimension	Key Components	Implementation Considerations
Technical Enablers	Edge computing architecture, IoT integration, Data governance systems, Security frameworks	Real-time processing capabilities, Sensor network optimization, Data quality management
Organizational Enablers	Change management frameworks, Governance structures, Stakeholder engagement	Capability development, Process redesign, Performance metrics
Systems Integration	Legacy system integration, Platform consolidation, API frameworks	Middleware solutions, Data migration protocols, Interface optimization

2) *Performance Monitoring and Optimization*: Continuous monitoring and optimization are crucial for long-term success:

a) *Key Performance Indicators*: Essential metrics for system evaluation encompass three critical areas: comprehensive system response time and accuracy metrics ensuring building operational efficiency [44], detailed resource utilization efficiency measures [45], and systematic occupant satisfaction and system adoption rate assessments [25].

b) *Optimization Frameworks*: Continuous improvement strategies incorporate three key components: systematic regular performance assessment protocols maintaining building system efficiency [43], sophisticated adaptive optimization techniques [47], and comprehensive occupant feedback integration methods [22].

F. Technology Adoption and Future-Proofing

Successful adoption requires comprehensive stakeholder engagement and support:

1) *Organizational Change Management*: Critical aspects of change management include:

a) *Stakeholder Engagement and Process Integration*: Key engagement strategies encompass: comprehensive training programs for building operators [48], robust communication frameworks [49], and effective occupant feedback integration mechanisms [50].

Essential integration considerations include: systematic building workflow optimization [51], comprehensive standard operating procedure updates [52], and robust performance monitoring protocols [53].

2) *Future-Proofing: Scalability Planning*: Ensuring long-term system viability requires forward-thinking approaches:

a) *Technical and Organizational Scalability*: Essential aspects comprise: robust building system expansion capabilities [1], advanced system integration flexibility [54], and sophisticated performance optimization mechanisms [55].

Critical organizational factors encompass: comprehensive resource allocation frameworks [56], systematic building op-

erator skills development, and robust knowledge management systems [57].

VI. SUSTAINABILITY AND CIRCULAR ECONOMY INTEGRATION

The integration of AI-enhanced digital twins with sustainability principles presents significant opportunities for optimizing building operations while minimizing environmental impact.

A. Circular Economy Implementation

1) *Material Lifecycle Management*: Digital twin implementations can support circular economy objectives through three key mechanisms: sophisticated real-time component tracking systems enabling lifecycle optimization [27], comprehensive material passporting systems facilitating reuse and recycling initiatives [42], and advanced waste reduction monitoring and optimization protocols enhancing resource efficiency [4].

2) *Digital Product Passport (DPP) Integration*: The European Union mandates DPPs for construction materials, emphasizing the need for accessible lifecycle tracking. The digital twin model addresses this by embedding a DPP framework aligned with international standards, monitoring key sustainability metrics and reuse potential [58]. It securely stores and updates this data from procurement through building operations. When components do not meet sustainability targets, the system alerts managers to support improved maintenance and material reuse across building portfolios.

3) *Resource Optimization*: Advanced AI frameworks enable three fundamental capabilities: Comprehensive integrated multi-sector resource optimization to enhance system efficiency, sophisticated dynamic energy consumption monitoring to ensure optimal usage, and advanced predictive maintenance systems to extend component operational life.

B. Environmental Impact and Sustainability Assessment

1) *Performance Metrics and Impact Optimization*: Key sustainability indicators encompass three critical measurements: comprehensive lifecycle carbon emissions tracking systems, detailed resource utilization efficiency metrics, and systematic waste reduction measurement protocols.

AI-driven optimization strategies focus on three core areas: comprehensive real-time building environmental impact monitoring systems, sophisticated adaptive control mechanisms ensuring resource efficiency, and advanced predictive modeling frameworks supporting sustainability planning.

The implementation of sustainability objectives requires four specific technical considerations: sophisticated real-time monitoring systems tracking energy and resource consumption [27], comprehensive integration of sustainability KPIs within digital twin dashboards, advanced automated optimization algorithms enhancing resource efficiency, and sophisticated machine learning models enabling predictive sustainability analytics. These technical implementations ensure that sustainability objectives are actively monitored and optimized within the digital twin framework.

2) *Human-Centric Sustainability*:

a) *Occupant Behavior Integration*: Critical considerations encompass three key elements: sophisticated occupant-aware system optimization protocols, comprehensive behavioral pattern analysis frameworks, and effective user engagement strategies ensuring system adoption.

b) *Social Impact Assessment*: Key social dimensions include three essential areas: ensuring equitable system access and benefit distribution across user groups, implementing culturally sensitive approaches in system deployment, and developing comprehensive stakeholder engagement frameworks supporting system success. This integration of sustainability and circular economy principles with AI-enhanced digital twins represents a crucial advancement in smart buildings, enabling more comprehensive and effective approaches to environmental impact reduction and resource optimization.

VII. TECHNOLOGY INNOVATION FRAMEWORK

The implementation of AI-enhanced digital twins represents a significant technological innovation in smart building automation and control, manifesting across both technical advancement and process transformation dimensions.

A. Technical Innovation Dimensions

Technical innovations show complementary strengths with distinct limitations:

AI architectures offer high optimization capacity, but face interpretability challenges best suited for non-critical functions. Digital twin implementations [3] provide superior visualization with intuitive interfaces, although at higher computational cost. These approaches complement each other—AI excels in pattern recognition while digital twins offer comprehensive modeling—suggesting benefits from integrated implementations.

B. Process Innovation Impact and Outcomes

These innovations transform building operational processes through automated decision-making frameworks that enable real-time optimization and predictive maintenance. Integration methodologies support seamless connectivity and process automation, enhancing operational efficiency [4].

Implementation has led to measurable improvements in system performance, evidenced by enhanced efficiency and improved resource utilization [27]. Capability advancements include extended functionality, improved reliability, and broader integration possibilities, demonstrating the transformative potential of AI-enhanced digital twins in smart buildings.

VIII. RESEARCH GAPS AND FUTURE DIRECTIONS

A. Research Gaps and Technical Challenges

Current research reveals several critical limitations:

a) *AI and Processing Capabilities*: Key challenges cover four critical areas: limited model interpretability reducing system trust [26], real-time processing constraints affecting operational efficiency, security and privacy protocol gaps requiring better protection [36], and insufficient integration between machine learning and physics-based models [41].

b) *Digital Twin Integration Challenges*: Critical gaps include incomplete real-time data integration of occupants [25], limited privacy-preserving frameworks [43], insufficient lifecycle metrics [22], and complex data quality management requirements [38].

B. Development and Implementation Priorities

Implementation priorities should focus on:

a) *AI Architecture and Edge Computing*: Priorities include AI architecture optimization [27], enhanced integration frameworks [3], improved scalability solutions [18], edge computing frameworks [15], and distributed processing architectures ensuring system reliability [30].

The adoption of edge computing in AI-enhanced digital twins presents both opportunities and challenges:

TABLE IX
EDGE COMPUTING TRADEOFFS IN BUILDING DIGITAL TWIN
IMPLEMENTATION

Aspect	Benefits	Challenges
Latency	Reduced response time, Real-time processing capability	Limited processing power, Resource constraints
Data Privacy	Enhanced data locality, Reduced transmission risks	Complex security implementation, Distributed vulnerability management
Scalability	Distributed processing capability, Reduced bandwidth needs	Hardware deployment costs, Maintenance complexity
Reliability	Continued operation during network issues, Local processing autonomy	Synchronization challenges, Redundancy requirements

These trade-offs significantly impact system design and implementation decisions [27].

b) *Data Management and System Integration*: Key developments include automated validation systems [29], real-time verification mechanisms [27], data cleaning pipelines [3], missing data handling protocols [15], and anomaly detection systems [30].

Implementation priorities include best-practice frameworks [22], risk mitigation approaches [18], load balancing frameworks [27], fault tolerance mechanisms [3], quality assurance protocols [29], and performance monitoring systems [30].

c) *Ethical and Social Implications*: Research on transparency, fairness, and equity in AI-driven interventions is still limited. Key areas requiring attention include: development of robust algorithmic transparency and accountability mechanisms, fair distribution of system benefits across user groups, ethical consideration in AI decision-making processes, and social impact assessment frameworks for system evaluation.

C. Future Research Directions

a) *Cross-Cutting Priorities*: Research needs include standardized data exchange protocols [27], integration of common ontologies [3], open-source validation platforms [18], and systematic model validation across contexts [22].

Critical areas requiring further investigation include:

b) *Advanced Applications*: Key directions are:

- **AI Integration**: Enhancing model interpretability, improving real-time processing [4], exploring federated learning for privacy, and developing GAN-based frameworks [13]
- **Circular Economy**: Digital twin integration with material passporting systems, lifecycle tracking mechanisms, and AI-driven waste reduction strategies
- **Human-Centric Systems**: Incorporating socio-cultural factors, developing adaptive occupant models, and implementing privacy-preserving frameworks
- **Policy Frameworks**: Developing real-time policy adaptation frameworks, designing dynamic incentive structures, and exploring regional regulatory approaches

These initiatives align technical advancements with sustainability objectives and human-centric considerations to maximize both efficiency and environmental benefits.

IX. CONCLUSIONS AND IMPLICATIONS

This comprehensive review yields several significant implications for both research and practice in smart buildings:

A. Key Conclusions

The analysis demonstrates three fundamental advances: substantial potential for AI-driven optimization in building systems [21], significant maturation in digital twin implementations [3], and development of sophisticated frameworks enabling successful building system integration [5].

B. Theoretical and Practical Implications

The analysis advances theory in several key areas:

AI Integration Theory: Extends existing frameworks for AI integration in building systems, with emphasis on autonomous

operation and decision-making. *Digital Twin Evolution*: Offers new insights into digital twin maturation in smart buildings. *Implementation Framework*: Proposes a theoretical framework for successful AI-enhanced digital twins implementation.

The findings offer valuable guidance for practitioners: *Implementation Strategy*: Provides concrete guidelines for organizations implementing AI-enhanced digital twins. *Risk Management*: Offers practical approaches for managing technical and organizational risks. *Performance Optimization*: Presents strategies to optimize system performance and ensure long-term sustainability.

MATCH & CONTRIBUTION

Aligned with ICE IEEE 2025's AI-driven transformation theme, this study shows how AI-enhanced and self-learning DTs, plus IoT/AI integration advance sustainable building-energy management. Its three-layer data→model→action framework and 15–30% energy-cost savings evidence value creation while addressing technical, organizational and integration barriers, furthering IEEE TEMS goals toward occupant-centric automation.

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